

YWCC307 - 016

BUSINESS PROJECT: FUNDSY

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Report on Research Process

Project Overview

The purpose of this project was to research existing social finance products and develop a new solution aimed at an underserved market. Through careful analysis of current financial tools, our team identified a significant gap in resources available to college students and young adults. Despite being highly active, entrepreneurial, and deeply connected to technology and social media, this group often struggles to secure funding for events, creative projects, startups, and personal initiatives. Traditional financial options like grants, loans, or sponsorships are often difficult to access, overly competitive, or not built with young people's realities in mind.

To address this need, we developed the concept for Fundsy, a social finance app created specifically for students and young professionals. Fundsy empowers users to create fundraising campaigns tied to specific goals, whether for a club event, a startup launch, a freelance project, or a creative endeavor. Through a collaborative platform, users can invite friends, peers, or broader networks to contribute and stay engaged by tracking fundraising progress, posting updates, and connecting with potential collaborators. The platform is built around familiar social interaction patterns, making financial support feel natural, accessible, and community-driven rather than transactional.

We chose this audience because students and young adults are uniquely positioned to benefit from a tool that blends social engagement with practical financial support. Fundsy goes beyond traditional crowdfunding models by fostering ongoing collaboration, accountability, and financial growth among its users. It not only provides an opportunity to raise funds but also promotes responsible money management and peer-driven success through gamified features, campaign tracking, and community building. Our goal with Fundsy is to help bridge the gap between ambition and opportunity for the next generation of changemakers.

Meeting Timeline & Decisions

Throughout the month of April, our team met consistently both in person and online to build this project from scratch. We kicked things off with an intro call on Discord, getting to know each other and figuring out what this “social finance” thing really meant. From there, Tuesdays became our in-person grind days, and Fridays at 5pm were our weekly check-ins via Discord calls, kind of like a virtual study session. Some weeks were full of brainstorming chaos (the good kind), and others were quiet because we were each locked in, working on our parts. The whole process was a mix of ideas, deadlines, memes, and Google Drive links flying around, but we pulled it together and saw it through as a team.

Meeting Format:

In-person: Tuesdays

Online (Discord calls): Fridays at 5 PM

Timeline: April 4th – April 25th

Meeting 1 : April 6 (Discord)

Focus: Team Setup & Understanding the Assignment

- Clarified project expectations: Create a social finance app concept
- Assigned initial app research (each member to find 2 apps)
- Created a team schedule for rotating meeting minute submissions
- Discussed creating a GitHub repository for submissions

Action Items:

- Everyone to research 2 apps by next meeting
- GitHub repository setup assigned (TBD)
- Alexander to submit this week's meeting minutes

Meeting 2 : Week of April 8 (In Person and Discord)

Focus: Features, Design Ideas, and Market Research

- Finalized target audience: students and youth
- Shared and discussed app research findings
- Identified gaps in current apps (Zirtue, Blossom, Revolut, etc.)
- Brainstormed app features
- Started putting ideas into PowerPoint slides

Began app design drafts

Meeting 3 : Week of April 15 (In Person and Discord)

Focus: Report and Slides Drafting

- Divided up roles for the final presentation and report
- Each member worked on their assigned section
- Coordinated slide progress and visuals

Shared feedback and edits during Discord calls

Meeting 4 : April 25 (Final Discord Call)

Focus: Finishing Touches

- Finalized slides and written report

- Uploaded all documents to GitHub repository
- Assigned presentation roles and practiced transitions
- Reviewed checklist to confirm all components were complete

App Research Summary

App Information

App Name	Category	Key Features	Target Audience
Zirtue	P2P Lending	Formal loan agreements, Custom repayment plans, Direct bill pay integration	Underserved individuals borrowing/lending within trusted circles
Blossom Social	Social Investing	Public portfolios, Social investing feed, Community education	Gen Z and Millennial beginner investors
Revolut	Digital Banking / Financial Super App	Banking services, P2P transfers, Crypto trading, Budgeting tools, Subscription tiers	Tech-savvy consumers looking for alternatives to banks

eToro	Social Trading / Investment Platform	CopyTrader, Multi-asset trading, Social trading feed, eToro Academy	Beginner and intermediate investors
Acorns	Fintech / Investment	Round-up investing, Automated saving and investing	Young adults, new investors
SoFi	Social Finance / Online Finance	Student loans, Banking, Investing, Financial planning	Young professionals and recent graduates
Trine Finance	Crowd Investing	Sustainable energy project investing in emerging markets	Impact investors focused on sustainability
Yotta	Prize-Linked Savings	Lottery-based savings rewards, FDIC-insured accounts	Budget-conscious individuals motivated by gamification
Splitwise	Expense Sharing / Debt Tracking	Bill splitting, IOU tracking, Venmo/PayPal integrations	Roommates, friends, couples, travel groups

Public.com	Commission-Free Investing with Social Features	Investing in stocks/ETFs, Social feed, Following other investors	Millennials and Gen Z retail investors
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App Strengths and Gaps

App Name	What Works Well	Gaps/ Opportunities
Zirtue	Trust-based lending, Flexibility, Direct essentials funding	Lacks social learning layer, Limited financial literacy, Not Gen Z friendly
Blossom Social	Transparent investing community, Addictive social features	Only investing focused, No savings or debt support, Can overwhelm finance beginners
Revolut	Easy digital banking, Subscription perks	No specific audience focus, Limited appeal to casual users, Weak social elements
eToro	Social trading network, Easy learning via copying	High fees, Limited crypto options
Acorns	Simple to use, Passive investment method	Monthly fees, Requires regular spending to maximize

		benefits
SoFi	No overdraft fees, Good saving tools	No traditional checking, Some security issues
Trine Finance	Specific project impact investing	Very narrow market, Limited general appeal
Yotta	Fun savings incentives, Safe banking	No group savings or fundraising features, No education support
Splitwise	Easy shared expense tracking, Great integrations	No fundraising, No pooling money, No financial planning tools
Public.com	Strong community, Educational investment space	No fundraising options, No direct group funding, Limited goal-based features

Target Market Justification

The primary users of our platform consist of college students together with young adults who fall within the age range of 18 to 25. The target group demonstrates advanced technological proficiency by using mobile applications for communication needs and organizational purposes and entertainment purposes. The demographic of college students and young adults receives

minimal financial solutions that address their specific life patterns. The current finance-related platforms fail to meet the needs of this age group because they remain complex and impersonal while lacking the social and collaborative features students typically use.

At this stage, students often collaborate on financial matters through sharing rent payments with flatmates and coordinating group outings and club events and operating small business ventures together. The widespread occurrence of shared financial management lacks user-friendly solutions that enable group financial management through social platforms. Fundsy solves this market gap through its user-friendly interface that combines social saving goals with peer monitoring functions and financial game elements.

Young adults stand at a crucial stage where they form their permanent financial behaviors. People in this stage of life handle their finances independently for the first time while lacking formal financial education. Fundsy creates a student-oriented interface which promotes budgeting and saving through social features that engage users. Users need help managing their money while the platform aims to develop positive financial behaviors that users find meaningful and rewarding.

College students together with young adults make up a big population that possesses unique financial requirements which current market offerings fail to address. Fundsy enables this specific audience to obtain empowerment through a platform which matches their lifestyle while facilitating financial growth and community-building through shared goals.

Intermediate Product Concepts

At the start of this project, we weren't entirely sure what direction to take our app in. The concept of "social finance" felt broad, and we found ourselves unsure of what exactly we were being asked to create. During our early meetings, we tossed around a lot of ideas. Many of them didn't stick; some were too complicated, and others felt too close to what already existed. It became clear that instead of trying to copy a polished product, we needed to think more personally. So we asked ourselves: what kind of finance app do we wish we had as students? That question helped shift our thinking. We weren't just building for a general audience. We were building for people like us: underrepresented, underfunded, and often overlooked in traditional financial spaces.

Once we made that mental shift, things started to come together. We looked at what apps like Zirtue and Blossom offered and where they fell short. We liked how Zirtue formalized peer lending and how Blossom made finance feel social; however, neither app felt fully grounded in student life. We wanted an app that allowed students to raise funds for things they cared about, like club events, personal projects, and startup ideas. We also wanted to create a space where students could find encouragement, advice, and maybe even teammates. We experimented with different feature ideas, including anonymous donations, budgeting tools, freelance listings, and mentorship boards. Eventually, we found a balance that made sense: project-based funding with a community-driven approach, specifically designed for students and young creators.

Naming the app was another process on its own. We threw around a lot of silly names and had quite a few laughs. Eventually, we landed on Fundy. It was simple and a little quirky, but it stuck. It felt like something a student might actually download and use. In a way, Fundy reflects us, creative, resourceful, and learning as we go. It became more than just a project; it

became a reflection of what we wish existed for people like us. Our team learned that building something meaningful doesn't always begin with confidence or clarity. Sometimes it begins with uncertainty, experimentation, and empathy, for ourselves and the community we hope to serve.

Final App Direction

Our app, **Fundsy**, is designed to create a new, student-centered approach to project-based fundraising. The purpose of Fundsy is to provide college students, youth organizations, and young entrepreneurs with a platform where they can raise funds for events, startups, and creative projects. At the same time, the app fosters meaningful connections between students by allowing users to discover campaigns they are passionate about and get directly involved, whether through financial support or collaboration.

Fundsy's main features focus on a dynamic campaign system. Users can create campaigns that include detailed project descriptions, photos, videos, and updates. These campaigns appear in a tunable social feed that mirrors the familiar feel of social media platforms. Users can like, comment, and interact with posts, making the funding process feel less transactional and more community-driven. Each campaign has its own profile page, showcasing updates, goals, donation trackers, and additional information posted by campaign managers. Campaigns may also include optional group chats that can be open to the public, restricted to donors, or entirely private, depending on the project leader's preference.

Revenue generation for Fundsy will come from two main streams. First, targeted advertising designed specifically for the student demographic will be integrated into the platform. Second, premium account features will be available for users seeking enhanced exposure and deeper campaign analytics. Premium users will have access to insights such as

viewership trends, donor engagement statistics, and campaign performance breakdowns, helping serious organizers grow their initiatives more effectively.

Fundsy draws inspiration from existing platforms but reimagines them for a younger, often underserved audience. It combines the campaign-driven funding model seen in apps like Trine Finance with the interactive, community-based social feed popularized by platforms like eToro. However, unlike broader crowdfunding or investing apps, Fundsy is uniquely built for students and young creators. It is not only about raising money; it is about fostering connection, accountability, and the collective drive to bring ideas to life. By blending fundraising with social interaction and project discovery, Fundsy offers a space where students can both seek support and find new opportunities to participate in meaningful work.

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